Hacktoberfest 2026

From pull-request counting to events, AI challenges, and community Fests

Research report | October 2026

Executive summary

- Hacktoberfest 2026 (October 2026) no longer counts pull requests or merge requests toward rewards.
- The old model was "open N PRs, earn a T-shirt."
- The new model centers on MLH- and DEV-run events, challenges, and participation stickers.
- Theme: "AI belongs to everyone"; DigitalOcean is presenting partner.
- Free to join for age 13+, subject to country and Fest rules.
- Best public mid-October counts: 531 Fests across 71 countries and 669,307 open hacktoberfest issues.

Key metrics

Metric	Value
Event window	October 2026
PRs / MRs count toward rewards	**No**
In-person Fests	300+ across 60+ countries
MLH events API (mid-Oct 2026)	**531 across 71 countries**
Open hacktoberfest issues	669,307
Unclaimed issues	**~517,632**
Repos with hacktoberfest topic	148,820
Repos with accepted label	**25,097**
Online swag threshold	3 / 10 / 15 (or 17) stickers
T-shirt promise	**Not promised online**

Participation decline over time

The shift did not happen in a vacuum: registered participants and eligible PRs had already fallen sharply.

Registered participants

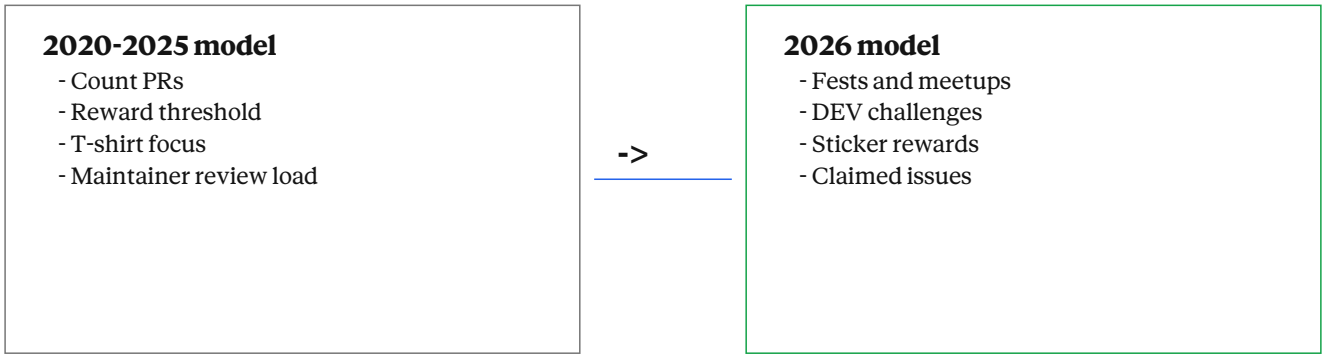
Eligible October PRs

Open issues (Oct 16, 2026)

Why the reward model changed

- Organizers cite maintainer feedback.
- AI made low-effort PR generation "trivial" while creating "no value."
- Maintainer burnout came from high volumes of box-checking PRs.
- 2020 saw 621,104 October PRs, 9,598 spam/invalid, and 172,599 sent to non-opted-in repos.
- Reforms included topic opt-in, accepted labels, and a 7-day review window.
- By 2025 the eligible-PR target rose from 4 to 6 and the T-shirt was capped at the first 10,000 "super contributors."
- An OpenSSF-attributed estimate says about 35% of Hacktoberfest-labeled PRs were closed without merging.

Model shift diagram



Event timeline

Window	Activity
Oct 1-4	DEV Weekend Challenge (deadline Oct 4, 11:59 PM PDT)
Oct 5-11	**DEV Week 1 challenge**
Oct 9-15	Global Hack Week: Hacktoberfest
Oct 12-18	**DEV Week 2 challenge**
Mid-Oct	MLH API: 531 Fests across 71 countries; 669,307 open issues
Oct 19-25	**DEV Week 3 challenge**
Oct 26-31	DEV Week 4 challenge
Post-Oct	**Retrospectives, attendance data, challenge quality, maintainer load**

Fest distribution (mid-October)

Country / group	Fests	Notes
India	224	Includes Bengaluru cluster
United States	**101**	**Second-largest visible cluster**
Other 69 countries	206	Derived: 531 total minus published two
Total	**531**	**MLH events API snapshot**

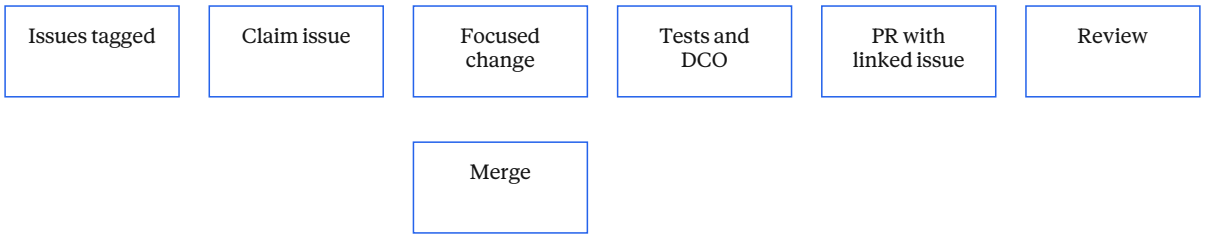
Access is uneven: some India events are invite-only with about 50 participants.

Issue backlog snapshot (Oct 16, 2026)

Metric	Value
Open hacktoberfest issues	669,307
Unclaimed issues	**~517,632**
Likely claimed/linked issues	~151,675 (derived)
Average annotated difficulty	**3.7 / 5**
Time estimate one day or less	11%
Issues opened prior 7 days	**~9,738**
Github hacktoberfest topic repos	148,820
Repos with accepted label	**25,097**

Contribution flow still matters

PRs no longer trigger rewards, but tagged issues and project workflows still move contributions through review.



Controversy and impact

- Pipeline concern: the October first-contribution flood that fed long-term contributor pipelines is de-targeted.
- Access concern: Fest availability appears uneven relative to country size, especially India.
- Corporate influence: many named sponsors shape the build-and-event narrative.
- Online swag grievance: no guaranteed T-shirt online; only in-person supplies or raffle items remain.
- Education claim: organizers cite 500+ Fests in 60+ countries and 3,000 projects in the first week.
- AI-slop concern: low-quality AI-assisted PR pressure persists year-round, not only in October.
- Historic impact examples: freeCodeCamp quiz questions grew from 694 to 1,171 in one October; Meilisearch hired a contributor within ten days of a first contribution.
- Verdict gap: no 2026 demographic data and the event was still running, so conclusions on inclusion and spam reduction are unverified.

Best practices

For maintainers	For contributors
Run CI gates: tests, no warnings, docs updates	Claim issues explicitly and wait for acknowledgment
Keep PRs roughly under 400 lines	**Respect scope and avoid cosmetic-only sweeps**
Publish CONTRIBUTING.md, templates, difficulty tiers	Write tests and link issues (Fixes #123)
Audit CI/CD and consider OpenSSF Scorecards	**Disclose AI use and own each contribution**
Use accepted labels, opt-in topics, review windows	Use the project before changing it
Define clear close messages and AI policies	**Submit focused diffs with reproduction details**

Conclusion

- Hacktoberfest 2026 separates community participation from PR volume accounting.
- Projects lose the October first-contribution flood but gain protection from review overload.
- Contributors gain claimable work and local onboarding but lose reward-linked feedback.
- Whether the model revives participation or marks managed decline depends on unpublished post-event metrics.
- Reward design remains the central lever in open-source participation programs.

Selected sources

- Hacktoberfest FAQ: https://hacktoberfest.com/questions/
- In-person and host pages: https://hacktoberfest.com/in-person/ and https://hacktoberfest.com/host/
- MLH blog: https://blog.mlh.com
- MLH events API: https://hacktoberfest-api.mlh.com/api/events
- DEV challenges: https://dev.to/challenges/hf26
- Global Hack Week: https://ghw.mlh.com/events/open-source
- GoodFirstIssue: https://www.goodfirstissue.org/labels/hacktoberfest
- GitHub topics: https://github.com/topics/hacktoberfest
- TrendForge: https://trendforge.devlive.org/report/topic/hacktoberfest/weekly/2026-10-11
- Developer Relations spam case study: https://developerrelations.com/case-studies/overcoming-hacktoberfest-spam/
- tvc-16 science analysis: https://tvc-16.science/rip-hacktoberfest.html
- openresource.dev: https://openresource.dev/articles/hacktoberfest/
- tamiz.pro: https://tamiz.pro/insights/hacktoberfest-2026-quality-first-open-source-habits
- Publicasta AI-slop radar: https://publicasta.com/open_source_radar/ai_slop_pull_requests_open_source_maintainers_2026_08_28
- Reddit discussions: https://www.reddit.com/r/hacktoberfest/comments/1vsuffw/hacktoberfest_2026_ai_belongs_to_everyone/